

SHORIGAN

AWAY FROM HOME

A Parallel Chronicle of the Shorigan Cycle

Chapter One: The Names We Keep From Ourselves



There is a rule older than the Verses themselves, and it is this: a Name spoken correctly cannot be unheard.

Anna Bell had built her entire life around never letting anyone get close enough to speak hers.



I.

The flat above the spice shop on Bree Street smelled of cardamom and rain by the time Anna Bell finally lay down. She had spent the evening as someone else — as Nomsa Adaeze, a name she wore the way other people wore coats, for a client in Rosebank who wanted a fracture in his family's inheritance mended before it curdled into a war of lawyers. She had done the work cleanly. She had left before he could thank her by name, because there was no true thanks to be given to a name that did not exist.

She showered until the last of Nomsa rinsed off her skin. She lit the ninth candle from the left on the windowsill, out of eleven, because nine was the number Cyn had once used to ward a door in a story so old it had eroded into scripture. She did not know if it worked. She did it anyway, the way a sailor touches the mast before a storm not because the wood listens, but because the hand needs somewhere honest to go.

Then she slept, and the ordinary machinery of Cape Town — the trains, the wind off the mountain, her mother's voicemail asking, again, when she was coming home to Gugulethu for her cousin's lobola negotiations — fell away beneath her like a tide going out.



II.

The Dream Realm received her as it always did: not as a place she arrived at, but as a place she remembered she had never left.

Here, Anna Bell did not disguise herself. There was no client to be, no alias to inhabit. Here she was simply herself, dressed in the version of herself the Realm thought was true — barefoot, in a dress the deep ochre of Karoo soil after rain, her locs unbound and moving very slightly as though underwater, though there was no water, only the dry gold light of a dream remembering what daylight felt like.

Lust was waiting for her in the shape of the last conversation she'd refused to finish.

He did not look like temptation the way the old tapestries painted it — no serpent, no honeyed smile. He looked like Themba, three years gone now, sitting at the small café table where he'd once asked her to stay a single extra day in Stellenbosch, and she had said no, work, and meant it, and regretted meaning it every night since. The Dream Realm did not lie about what a person wanted. It only lied about whether wanting was safe.

"You could stay this time," Dream-Themba said, and poured her a coffee that smelled exactly, unbearably, correctly like the real one. "Nobody's counting the days in here."

The Sight showed her the seams before her heart could argue with them. Beneath the table, where the tablecloth should have pooled in shadow, there was instead a thread of gold — thin, taut, tied around her own ankle and vanishing off toward a door that was not a door, only an absence shaped like leaving.

She understood, then, what Lust was actually offering. Not Themba. Not even the coffee. It was offering her permission to stop choosing. To let the thread pull her rather than walk it herself.

"You're very good at this," she told him, and meant it as a professional courtesy, one craftsman to another. "But you've made a mistake anyone would make. You assumed I want to be pulled."

She knelt — not in surrender, in inspection — and with the Tongue she spoke four words to the thread itself, not to Themba, not to the shape wearing his face. Names had a grammar, and objects, unlike people, could not lie about what they were once you addressed them correctly. The thread did not resist. It had never been built to. It simply remembered it was rope, and rope, spoken to honestly, agrees to be untied.

Dream-Themba's smile did not break so much as it became briefly, terribly old — the true face beneath the borrowed one, tired the way all the Adversaries were tired, doing this same dance every night since dreaming began.

"You didn't want me gone," Lust said, almost gently, almost like something that could be hurt. "You wanted to be the one who decided."

"Yes," Anna Bell said. "That's the whole of it."

He went the way morning takes fog — not defeated, only reminded of the time.



III.

Distraction did not bother pretending to be a person. She had learned, over however many centuries an Adversary keeps count, that Anna Bell's mind was not a door you knocked on. It was a room already full of doors, and the trick was never to be one of them, only to be the reason none of them got opened.

The dream fractured into errands. A message from her mother that needed answering. A ward on the Rosebank client's threshold that she was nearly certain — nearly, not certain — she'd left unfinished. A memory of Cyn's verse, half-remembered, that itched like a word on the tip of the tongue. Twelve small unfinished things bloomed around her all at once, each one perfectly reasonable, each one just urgent enough to reach for.

The Sight watched her reach for the ward first, out of habit, and then made her notice something she would have missed a year ago: none of the twelve things had a shadow. Every real concern in her life cast one. These were images of concerns, hollow the way a puppet is hollow, animated from somewhere behind her rather than from within themselves.

She almost laughed, and the almost-laugh was the first weapon, because Distraction thrived on solemnity, on the held breath of a person who believes every open door deserves equal fear.

"You want me scattered," she said, to the twelve doors, to none of them and all of them. "You think a Namer's gift is precision, so you're trying to give me too much to be precise about."

She did not choose one door. She did not close her eyes to all of them, either, the way discipline alone might have counseled. Instead she did the thing her training had never quite taught her, the thing that came from somewhere further back than training — she used the Presence.

Not to dominate the room. To become the room's center of gravity.

Twelve doors are only distracting if they are all equally worth attending to. Anna Bell simply stopped, and stood, and let herself be the stillest, most present thing in the space — and the doors, which existed only to compete for her attention, found they had nothing left to compete against. Attention was not something Distraction could steal from her if Anna Bell had already given it entirely to herself.

The twelve doors thinned like breath on cold glass, and were gone, and what was left was only Distraction herself, unclothed of her tricks, looking at Anna Bell with something that might have been respect, if Adversaries were built to hold respect the way people were.

"Everyone else runs toward the fire that looks most urgent," Distraction said.

"I know," Anna Bell said. "That's how you've been winning for a thousand years. It was never about how many doors you could open. It was about whether I remembered I was the one holding the house."

This was, though she did not know it yet, the truest sentence she would speak all night. It was also, though she could not know this at all, a sentence that would matter again in a book not yet written, in a year not yet arrived.



IV.

Rage did not enter the way the other two had. He did not need permission from the dream's grammar, because Rage never asks the space what it is willing to become. He simply arrives, and the space rearranges itself around the fact of him, the way a room rearranges itself around a dropped stone.

The gold light guttered. The café, the doors, the ochre dress — all of it curled at the edges like paper too near a flame, and what stood in the clearing left behind was not wearing anyone's face. It did not need to borrow grief to be convincing. It had found something worse than grief.

It had found the chain.

Anna Bell felt it before she saw it: the old, familiar weight across her shoulders that she carried every day in the waking world and had never once, in seven years of Dreaming, felt inside the Realm. Her family's expectations. The elders' quiet disappointment folded into every "when are you settling down." The unspoken understanding that a Namer of her bloodline did not get to simply want things for herself. It was supposed to stay outside the door of sleep. Rage had found the door and walked it in.

"You've never let me hold this," Rage said, in a voice that was, horribly, her own. "Everyone else, you outthink. Me, you've just been carrying. Every single day. Let's see what happens when you finally put it down all at once."

He did not attack her sight, or her tongue, or her poise. He attacked the chain itself — hauled on it with a strength that had nothing to do with muscle and everything to do with years, and Anna Bell felt something she had never felt in the Dream Realm before.

She felt afraid that she might not wake up.

Her Sight, which had shown her thread and shadow and seam all night, showed her now the true shape of the danger, and it was not a monster. It was a truth: that some part of her had, in fact, never put the chain down, not once, not for one single day since she'd first understood what it meant to be

born a Namer descended from Cyn — and Rage did not need to invent a weapon. He only needed to pick up the one she had spent her whole life sharpening against herself.

She tried the Tongue. Words failed her, because the chain was not a lie she could correct; it was a truth she had built. She tried the Presence. The room did not reorganize around her stillness, because there was no stillness in her left to organize around — Rage had found the one place in her where she had never once, not for a single breath, been at peace.

She went to her knees on the ashen ground, and for the first time in longer than she could remember, Anna Bell — Namer, descendant of Cyn, keeper of a name so hidden even she sometimes had to search for it in her own chest — understood what it would feel like to lose.

Not to wake up frightened.

To stop, in a way that had nothing to do with sleep.



V.

He arrived the way a person arrives in a house whose address they misread — apologetic before they understand what they've walked into.

Alexander had lost to Lust an hour before, in his own Dream, in a battle he would think about with more shame than the loss deserved. He had lost to Distraction after that, more thoroughly, in a way that would sting for exactly as long as his pride let it. Rage he had beaten only in the last hour before dawn, and not the way any of the training texts told him he was supposed to — not by outlasting it, not by reasoning with it, not by any of the disciplines that worked, more or less, on Lust and on Distraction if a man was patient enough.

Rage did not want to be reasoned with. It wanted a fight it could not lose, and every attempt he made to argue with it, or wait it out, had only fed it, the way a fire is fed by anything at all that is not water. What broke the pattern — and he did not yet have a name steady enough to hang on it, only a word half-remembered from a training text so old its cover had come apart in his hands — was the moment he stopped trying to survive the exchange and simply gave Rage the one thing it was not built to expect: total, unflinching commitment to ending it, with no part of himself held back to protect afterward.

The old text had called that aspect only *Kill*. Not because anything needed to die. Because the technique demanded he set down, for the length of one exact moment, every instinct that wanted him to still be standing, whole and safe, once it was over. He had done it clumsily, in a rough and unfinished shape, the way a boy swings a sword he has only ever read about — and it had worked anyway, because Rage cannot bargain with someone who has stopped bargaining for his own

survival.

He did not understand yet what he had found. He only knew it had cost him something to use, and that the cost was the reason it had worked at all.

And then — because the Dream Realm keeps its own private geography, and because the boundary between two dreamers' nights sometimes thins for reasons even Isor does not explain — he took one more step, meaning to go home, and found himself standing at the edge of somebody else's grief instead.

He did not know whose. He only knew, immediately and without needing telling, that he was somewhere he had not been invited.

He saw a woman on her knees in ash-colored light, and something wearing her voice standing over her with a chain that existed nowhere but inside her, and — this was the thing Rage had not accounted for, the thing no Adversary training against a single dreamer ever accounts for — Alexander was not carrying that chain. It had never been forged for him. It meant nothing to his shoulders.

Rage turned, sensing the intrusion, already reaching to make Alexander's presence into a new weapon — but there was nothing of hers in him to sharpen against. He did not fear the chain, because it had never been forged for his shoulders. He simply saw a woman being hurt, and a thing standing over her wearing her own voice like a stolen coat, and some part of him recognized the shape of the fight before the rest of him had finished arriving at it.

He stepped between them.

"That's not yours to carry alone," he said — not quite to Rage, not quite to Anna Bell, though it landed on both of them at once. It was almost the same sentence that had cracked his own fight open an hour before. This time it cost him nothing to say, because the weight underneath it belonged to someone else. That was the whole of the difference. Against his own Rage, the aspect he'd found — the one the old text called only *Kill* — had demanded he surrender his own safety to end the exchange. Here, he had no safety of his own left in the wager. He was only spending a stranger's fear back at the thing that had stolen it, and a man can afford to be total, unbargaining, unflinching, when none of what he's risking is his to lose.

He did not so much strike Rage as refuse it any further room to negotiate — the same rough, unfinished shape of the technique, aimed outward this time instead of in, all commitment and no leverage, the kind of blow the old manuals warned took years to learn to aim without losing yourself inside it. He had not learned that part yet. Tonight it did not matter. Rage had built its entire strength on the premise that a person's worst weight is theirs uniquely, privately, unbearably alone — and it had never once been tested against someone willing to end the argument rather than win it.

Rage did not roar. Something older than roaring happened — a long, cracking silence, like ice deciding, at last, to become water — and then he was gone the way all the Adversaries eventually go: not destroyed, only returned to wherever they wait out the daylight, already rehearsing tomorrow night's version of themselves.



VI.

For one heartbeat — no longer, the Realm would not permit longer — Anna Bell simply knelt in the ash-light with a stranger's hand not quite touching her shoulder, and let herself believe, entirely, that she was safe.

She had not done that in years. Not with her mother. Not with Themba, even at his kindest. Not once, not fully, not without some private sentry standing watch behind her ribs counting exits. But the fight had emptied her of the strength required to keep the sentry posted, and in the single unguarded second before her discipline could reassemble itself, every wall she had built around the deepest room in her went, very briefly, transparent.

Alexander did not go looking for what was behind that door. He was not the kind of man who searched. But a thing does not have to be searched for to be seen, when it stands close enough and the light is honest enough, and something in him — not the Sight, he had no Sight, only the plain unguarded attention of a man watching a stranger stop being afraid — simply recognized what it was looking at, the way you recognize a word you learned before you could remember learning it.

"Anna Bell," he said.

He did not say it like a discovery. He said it the way you'd say a name you'd always known, surprised only that you'd needed to say it at all.

The ash-light did not change. Nothing in the Dream Realm so much as flickered. And yet the entire architecture of Anna Bell's carefully unnamed life came down at once, silent and total, like a house whose every load-bearing wall is removed in the same instant — the house does not groan first. It simply is standing, and then it is not.



VII.

Terror, when it came, did not look like anger. It looked like stillness so absolute it had a texture, like held breath given a body.

"What did you do," she said. It was not a question. Questions leave room for an answer you haven't already decided you can't survive.

"I don't—" Alexander started, and had no end to the sentence, because he genuinely did not know. He had heard a name the way you hear your own heartbeat: present the entire time, noticed only once.

Anna Bell did not wait to find out whether he understood what he'd done. Understanding was a luxury for afterward, if there was an afterward. Right now there was a stranger standing in her Dream holding the single thing she had spent her entire adult life ensuring no living person held, and every discipline she had ever built screamed the same single, simple imperative: make this unhappen, by any means available.

She came at him with all three Gifts at once, which she had never done, because a Namer is taught from childhood that the three Gifts in true concert are meant for the direst hour of a life, not spent lightly, not spent in practice, not spent on an ordinary stranger who had wandered somewhere he shouldn't have been.

The Tongue tried a dozen Verses meant to unmake, to erase a spoken thing from a mind that held it — and every one of them failed, because a true Name, once truly heard, is not information. It cannot be redacted the way a sentence can. It is closer to a scar. The Sight, turning inward instead of outward for the first time in the fight, showed her, in one merciless flash, that there was no version of this where the name went back into hiding. And the Presence, which had always drawn rooms toward her gently, turned instead into something closer to gravity given teeth, an insistence that the whole Dream Realm agree with her that this had not happened.

Alexander did not fight back. He absorbed what he could, staggered under what he couldn't, and did not once raise a hand against her, because some instinct even older than the Realm's rules told him that whatever he had done, it had not been done with malice, and a thing done without malice did not deserve to be answered with a killing blow.

He was on one knee, breath gone ragged, the Dream itself bruised black-blue at its edges from the force she had spent, when the world simply — stopped.



VIII.

Isor did not arrive so much as the moment arrived at him.

The ash-light held itself perfectly still, mid-collapse, a wave that had forgotten how to finish breaking. Anna Bell found she could not complete the motion of her own raised hand. Alexander found he could not fall the rest of the way to the ground he'd been falling toward. Only Isor moved,

unhurried, ancient, wearing patience the way other beings wear skin.

"You have wandered into a room that was not built for you," he said to Alexander, and there was no anger in it, only the particular gravity of a teacher correcting a mistake he had, perhaps, half expected all along. "Every night has a door. Yours opened onto hers. That is not a crime. What you did once you were inside it — that is the part you will spend a long time understanding."

He turned, and something in his manner toward Anna Bell was gentler, and somehow more exacting for its gentleness.

"And you," he said, "have spent so many years guarding the door that you forgot the house has a person living in it. You built the wall so well you started to believe you were the wall. A Name kept from every enemy is a discipline. A Name kept from yourself is a kind of dying no Adversary needs to arrange. Rage did not only find your chain tonight, child. He found it because you have been standing in the exact same spot holding it for seven years, refusing to notice your own arms were tired."

Neither of them understood, fully, what he meant. That was, Anna Bell would come to learn, generally the point.

"I am not returning things to how they were," Isor said, to both of them, though his eyes did not leave Alexander's. "What is heard cannot be unheard. But what is heard does not have to be used. That will be his choice to make, every day, for as long as he carries it. And yours, to decide what it costs him if he chooses wrongly."

He lifted one hand, unhurried, and the Dream Realm folded around Alexander the way water closes over a stone dropped from a great height — not violent, only complete.

"Go home," Isor told him. "You did not do it to hurt her. That will matter more than you know, and less than you'd like."

And then Alexander was gone, pulled back through whatever door had let him wander in, and the ash-light dream of Anna Bell's night belonged, once more, only to her.



IX.

She expected the silence that followed to feel like violation.

It felt, instead — and this frightened her far more than Rage ever had — like relief.

She stayed on her knees a while longer, not because her strength had not returned, but because she did not yet trust what she would do standing. Isor watched her with the specific patience of

something that had watched a great many people arrive at exactly this kind of silence before.

"Say it," he told her finally. "Not to me. I already know it. Say it so you remember you're the one who knows it too."

"He didn't take anything from me," Anna Bell said, and her own voice sounded unfamiliar to her, thinner than her professional register, closer to the girl she'd been in Gugulethu before she learned to sound like a woman no one could get a hold of. "He just... heard what was already there. I've been so busy hiding it I forgot it was mine before it was a secret."

"Yes," Isor said. "That is the part almost no one survives learning gracefully. You will not either, not entirely, not tonight. That's permitted."

The dream-light shifted, warmed by a degree that had nothing to do with any sun. Two shapes arrived, the way weather arrives — not summoned, simply due.



X.

Lady Loss came first, or perhaps she had always been standing at the edge of the ash-light, watching, the way she watched everything eventually, patiently, without malice, the way a tide is not malicious about the shoreline it is nonetheless certain to take.

"Cyn's blood," she said, and there was something almost fond in it, the fondness of an old creditor for a debt she has watched grow interesting rather than merely large. "I have been waiting to see what you did with a chain that heavy. Most of your line simply drops it, eventually. Sets it down in a marriage, or a grave, or a war they didn't start. You are the first in three generations who tried to carry it and outrun it at the same time. I confess, I have found that entertaining."

"You watch me because you enjoy it," Anna Bell said. It was not quite an accusation. She was too tired for accusations.

"I watch you," Lady Loss said, "because your line has cost me a great deal over a great many years, and I have learned to take my payment in attention when I cannot yet take it in anything else. Cyn owed me something, once, that was never fully settled. Debts like that do not vanish. They wait for an heir with enough left to lose."

She did not say more. She did not need to. Anna Bell understood, with the particular chill of a truth arriving before she was ready for it, that this was not a threat so much as a weather forecast — Lady Loss was not promising to take something from her. She was simply present for the possibility, the way rain is present for a river, whether or not it falls that day.



Lady Luck arrived the way she always did, opposite and inseparable, laughing at nothing in particular, the sound of someone who has never once needed a reason.

"Don't let her gloom you," she said, to Anna Bell, though her eyes were on Lady Loss with the specific delight of two old rivals who had long since stopped pretending they weren't also, in some unspeakable way, in love with the game between them. "I've followed this one since Themba's coffee, if we're keeping score. Every time she chooses instead of drifting, I get interested. You didn't drift tonight, little Namer. Twice you could have. You chose instead, both times, and my kind finds a chooser irresistible. We follow choosers. Debtors and drifters, we let the tide have. Choosers, we stay for."

"I didn't choose to be found tonight," Anna Bell said.

"No," Lady Luck agreed, delighted rather than corrected. "That part wasn't yours. That part was mine, or hers, or his, or all three of us arguing over a door none of us actually opened. But what you do with having been found — that's the part I'll be back for. I always come back for the interesting part."

Isor said nothing to either of them, which Anna Bell understood, without being told, was its own kind of answer — that these two were neither fully controlled by him nor fully opposed to him, that they belonged to a category of the world's workings that even the ancient and patient did not presume to referee.



XI.

"The Concord Mantle is not finished," Isor said, once the Ladies had gone the way weather goes, without announcement, leaving only the changed pressure of the air behind them. "Nor the Borrowed Throne. You know this. What you did not know, until tonight, is why."

"The First Verse," Anna Bell said. It was not a question either.

"A Mantle that lets you hold another's burden without losing your own shape requires you to have first admitted you were carrying one," Isor said. "A Throne borrowed rather than seized requires you to have first been willing to let someone else stand close enough to see you sitting in it unguarded. You could not complete either working while you were still pretending the chain wasn't yours, or that no one could ever be close enough to see you kneel."

"So Rage was necessary."

"Rage is always necessary," Isor said, without cruelty, the way a person states the tide comes in. "Not because it is kind. Because it is honest, in the one way none of your disciplines can afford to

be. It will not be the last time it finds that door. But you now know the door exists. That is not nothing. That is, in fact, most of the work."

Anna Bell looked down at her own hands, steady again, and thought of Alexander's face in the instant before the name had left him — not triumphant, not cunning, simply a man remembering something he had never been taught. She thought of her mother's voicemail, still unanswered in the waking world, asking when she was coming home. She thought of the word home, and noticed, for perhaps the first time in years, that she no longer knew with total certainty what city it pointed to.

"Will I see him again?" she asked, and hated how much she wanted the answer to be yes, hated it the specific, familiar way she hated every want she had ever tried to starve into silence.

Isor's answer, when it came, was the kind she would turn over for a long time afterward, in the particular way certain sentences refuse to finish arriving all at once.

"Two lives that learn each other's Names," he said, "however it happens, however unwilling either party was — those lives do not simply return to being separate afterward. Not because a law forbids it. Because a law was never needed. It is closer to a wound that heals crooked: the bone does not care whether you consented to the break. It only cares how it sets."

He watched her absorb that, patient as stone, and then added the last thing, quietly, almost as an afterthought, though nothing Isor said was ever truly an afterthought.

"Go home, Anna Bell. Not the one your mother is calling about. The other one. You'll know it by how little it resembles anywhere you've been standing all these years, guarding a door with nothing dangerous left behind it but you."



The ash-light dimmed, the way morning dims a candle rather than extinguishing it, and Cape Town's ordinary machinery came rushing back up to meet her — the trains, the wind off the mountain, the ninth candle from the left burned down to a stub she had not noticed guttering.

Anna Bell woke with her name — her true name, the one she had spent a lifetime keeping from the world and, it turned out, from herself — sitting in her chest like something finally let in out of the cold.

She did not know yet what it would cost her.

She only knew, lying very still in the grey Cape Town dawn, that for the first time in longer than she could remember, she was not afraid to find out.